Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[The Mountain sat upon the Plain]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the speaker's awareness of and appreciation for nature in Dickinson's "[The Mountain sat upon the Plain]" include

chiasmus,
connotation,
controlling image,
hapax legomenon,
imagery,
metaphor,
personification,
simile,
symbol, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize the mountain's central rôle as paternal precursor to all we encounter in our day-to-day walk through the world, as synecdochally represented by the plain and by the all-embracing seasons.

The contestant might begin a discussion of the relationship between the mountain and the plain by noting the speaker's personification of the mountain, which is followed by a once-removed personification (by way of simile) of the seasons, and the seasons' "playing" might well be understood as simple personification rather than metaphor.

The contestant should recognize and speak to the plain's having evolved from the mountain, perhaps in terms more metaphysical than erosion. The "inquest" (line 4)—the evidence of the mountain's having, like a father, sired the plain around him—suggests, by connotation, the circle of life motif.

The "tremendous chair" (line 2), perhaps a commanding throne, perhaps god-like, initially defines the relationships for which the mountain is central, which is then reinforced by the mountain's guardianship role: his "observation omnifold" (line 3). The description "Grandfather of the days" (line 7) reinforces the guardianship metaphor.

Something might be made of the mountain's relationship to/with the dawn, his being "there" before the dawn's light actually reveals him—thus the mountain as ancestor (line 8).